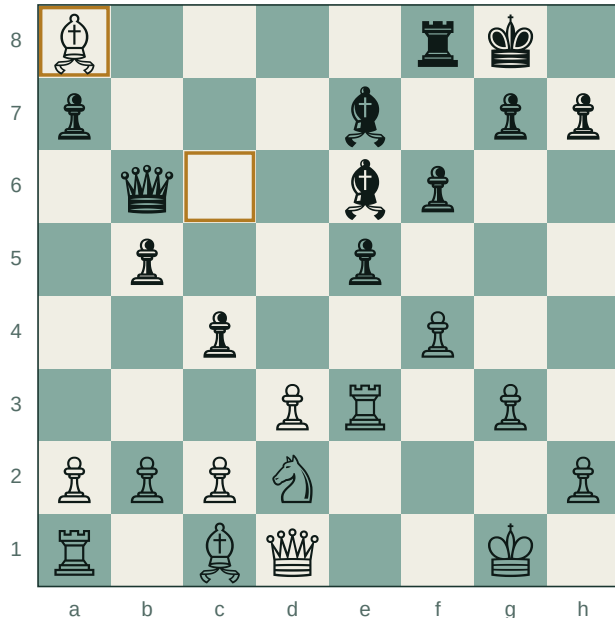


Intermediate moves: Black, move 16

Intermediate moves

Black to move



Previous move: 16.Bxa8. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

16...Qxe3+ 17. Kg2 Rxa8

16...Qxe3+ Check restricts White to 3 legal replies here. From e3 it attacks king on g1 and knight on d2. Recorded reply: **17.Kg2**.

17...Rxa8 The rook captures the bishop on a8.

At the end, nominal material is White 27 / Black 27 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +8. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +8:** the balance goes from -8 to +0. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

The postponed recapture may disappear. The intermediate move must win enough or preserve the right to recover material.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

An intermediate move interrupts an expected sequence with a stronger immediate threat. Instead of recapturing automatically, use a check or another forcing move to change the result.

HOW TO LOOK

Before every routine recapture, scan checks, queen attacks, and mating threats. Return to the original capture only if it still helps.

The defending king is on g1. Absolute pin: rook on e3.